

Rhetoric usage in Pokémon Design Analysis

What makes a character design memorable? Is it their silhouette, the color palette, or the hidden story that is shown in its anatomy? In the new age of short form videos, content creators have found a surprisingly reliable format for unpacking these questions, in the means of delivering nuanced design analysis in the 1-to-3-minute range. In TBSkyen's YouTube Short analyzing the Pokémon Reshiram, the creator argues on the deliverance of the design as he references other real-world concepts in a means to solidify his analysis. Through a blend of visual evidence, community knowledge, and a critical tone, the video demonstrates how short form content can be both rhetorically persuasive and still retain some substance, even with the tight constraints. TBSkyen effectively uses rhetorical strategies and persuades viewers by referencing Tao as a major theme of this work and how its intent is meaningful, though the short form content sacrifices the depth needed to fully support the claim.

The video first homes in on the claim that Reshiram and their counterpart Zekrom from the Pokémon Black and White games are a reference to the Tao, which may not be surprising to say the least. The Tao in this scenario being noted as a type of understanding set in the form of dualities. They are seen as complementary and also the complete opposite as they encircle one another. He sets the narrative that your job as a person is to find the balance between the yin and yang or also "male and female, nature and civilization" in TBSkyen's words or in this case between black and white. He proclaims the idea that Reshiram is meant to represent the white side of the symbol and is the complement to Zekrom. This can be seen in one example like Reshiram's design where it is spiky, soft and almost animalistic; while their counter part is

smooth, hard, and almost robotic. Later on, he focuses on designs weakness as while it is stark and striking it “suffers a little bit from a marketing design”, which can be seen as the design tries to look superficially cool rather than introducing more of the Yin and Yang aspect. He later concedes that he does not particularly mind this considering their original audience.

Throughout the video he uses multiple rhetorical strategies to prove his argument around the effectiveness of Reshiram’s design. The first way he goes about this is by trying to keep a professional tone, even when the content he is analyzing has an audience intended for children. It creates the message that the grading being perceived is reliable and consistent compared to others that might have analyzed this design before. It also matches his other rhetoric of concession, in which he adds criticism to the design later on in order to maintain a fair and impartial point of view. TBSkyen implies this when he says that “It has to look superficially cool and elaborate and powerful, and a lot of the details and features on the design feel motivated by *that*” which is meant to be implicative of the aforementioned ‘marketing design’. Coincidentally the duality he mentions earlier also goes side by side by side showing its more interesting traits and contrasting them against the design given by the Pokémon company, it creates the idea that while it is a good design it does have some small failures even if he does enjoy that latter aspect.

/*Go into appeals more heavily (Ethos, Logos, Pathos) hopefully if there is enough space for it (add screenshots later, it is important to note that visuals were not the focus except for showing key design notes that helped their narrative)

Conclusion will probably focus on the total effectiveness of their analysis and whether or not any failures affected their final result. */

Work Cited

TBSkyen [@TBSkyenShorts]. (2026, June 7). *Reshiram is VERY interesting, but a bit messy.*
#pokemon [Video]. YouTube Shorts. [https://
https://www.youtube.com/shorts/qUizpA9X1OE](https://www.youtube.com/shorts/qUizpA9X1OE)